



British Social Attitudes 2025 – experiment data: User Guide

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By really understanding the complexity of people's lives and what they think about the issues that affect them, we give the public a powerful and influential role in shaping decisions and services that can make a difference to everyone. And as an independent, not for profit organisation we're able to put all our time and energy into delivering social research that works for society.

National Centre
for Social Research
35 Northampton Square
London EC1V 0AX
020 7250 1866

www.natcen.ac.uk

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1. British Social Attitudes

The British Social Attitudes survey has been running since 1983. During that time, we have surveyed more than 120,000 members of the public, each year asking over 3,000 people a range of questions about their attitudes on a variety of topics ranging from welfare and the economy to politics and healthcare. (The survey was not run in 1988 and 1992 when we ran the British Election Study series, which included relevant attitudinal questions.)

The British Social Attitudes (BSA) surveys inform the development of public policy and are an important barometer of public attitudes used by opinion leaders and social commentators. The topics we cover in each survey are determined by the interests of our funders, some questions have been asked every year, others every couple of years, and others less frequently. Repeating some questions over time means that we are able to provide a unique insight into how social attitudes have changed during the last four decades.

Each year we publish a report, freely available online, using the data we have collected to present a compelling picture of Britain's social, moral and political attitudes. The report chapters can be found on the BSA website: natcen.ac.uk/british-social-attitudes

2. Accessing the data

Users from non-commercial organisations can download the data directly from the UK Data Service. Access to the data will require logging in via a university or research organisation, or otherwise registration. You can download the data as SPSS or STATA files, or as a TAB file. Data is archived around a year after the completion of fieldwork (giving time for analysis and reporting).

Commercial organisations must notify the National Centre for Social Research by email (BSA@natcen.ac.uk) stating their intended use and seeking permission for download. Permission to download may incur a charge. UKDS will be monitoring usage and providing NatCen with usage reports.

3. The sample

The British Social Attitudes survey is designed to yield a representative sample of adults aged 16 or over. Since 1993, the sampling frame for the survey has been the **Postcode Address File** (PAF), a list of addresses (or postal delivery points) compiled by the Post Office. For practical reasons, the sample is confined to those living in private households. People living in institutions (though not in private households at such institutions) are excluded, as are households whose addresses are not on the PAF.

A sample file of non-clustered addresses was produced from the PAF. 28,375 total addresses were then allocated to a main sample (N=23,646) and a reserve sample (n=4,729). The reserve sample was not issued in 2025.

Selection of individuals

Up to two individuals aged 16 or over living at the selected addresses were eligible to take part. The invitation and reminder letters contained two unique access codes allowing any two adults aged 16+ living within the household to log in and complete the survey.

4. Fieldwork

Fieldwork was carried out between 26th August and 5th October 2025.

Fieldwork used a mixed-mode design, offering the choice of both web and telephone survey completion. The fieldwork period was the same for both modes. The invitation and first reminder letters sent to respondents encouraged participants to take part online, while giving them the option to take part by phone if they wanted to. The letter and first reminder emphasised the option to take part by web. The second reminder letter made the option to take part by phone more explicit.

Telephone interviews were conducted by interviewers from NatCen's Telephone Unit. Before fieldwork, interviewers attended a briefing to familiarise themselves with the questionnaire and the study. A total of 48 interviews were conducted via phone and 4,679 completed via web.

The push-to-web approach for BSA 2025 allowed up to two people per household to participate in the survey. When taking into consideration the estimated number of eligible adults per address and the estimated proportion of deadwood or ineligible addresses the individual and household level response rates can be calculated.

Table 4.1 BSA 2025 response rate

Table 2 BSA 2025 response rate			
	Full Sample	Incentive Control Group	Incentive Experiment Group
Issued addresses	23,646	11,823	11,823
Estimated proportion deadwood/ineligible ¹	10%	10%	10%
Estimated number of eligible addresses	21,281	10,641	10,641
Number of addresses with at least one productive (full or partial)	3,542	1,810	1,732
Unadjusted household response rate ²	15%	15.3%	14.6%
Adjusted household response rate ³	16.6%	17.0%	16.3%
Estimated number of eligible individuals per household	1.9	1.9	1.9
Estimated number of eligible adults	40,435	20217	20217
Number of fully productive individual interviews	4,656	2,394	2,262
Number of partially productive individual interviews	71	34	37
Number of productive individual interviews per address (full or partial)	1.33	1.34	1.33
Estimated adjusted individual response rate	11.7%	12.0%	11.4%

¹ Estimate based on BSA 2019 % of ineligible

² The number of households with at least one response as a proportion of all issued addresses

³ The number of households with at least one response as a proportion of all the eligible sample (i.e. adjusted for deadwood/ineligible)

Advance mailings

Sampled addresses were sent an advance letter on the 26th of August, inviting adults aged 16 or over and resident at the household to take part in the survey. Up to two adults could take part in each household. Participants had the option to complete the survey via web or by telephone. Non-responsive households were sent three reminder letters, which included the access codes for the web survey and the BSA telephone contact number.

Incentives

On completion of the survey respondents were offered a shopping voucher to be sent via email or post. In 2025, an incentive experiment was conducted to determine whether the use of differential incentives could have a positive effect on the distribution of response by area deprivation. The sample was divided into two equal groups. The 'control' group were all offered a £15 conditional incentive. In the 'experiment group', those living in the two most deprived quintiles for area deprivation were offered a £20 conditional incentive, those living in the third most deprived quintile were offered a £15 conditional incentive, and those living in the two least deprived were offered a £10 conditional incentive. The exception were addresses in London, given lower response rates in London compared with other regions. For London addresses in the experiment group, the two most deprived areas were offered a £20 incentive, while others were offered £15.

5. Weighting the data

There is a weight variable included in the dataset (BSA25_experiment_wt), which can be used when conducting analysis of response rates by experiment group. The weight was created to correct for deliberate oversampling of the control group by IMD stratum in the issued sample. Without adjustment, any analysis of the Incentive Experiment that compares response rates between the control and experiment groups would be biased because the control group is not equally distributed across IMD strata. Every control case was given a weight that scales its influence up or down so that, within each stratum, the weighted sizes of control and experiment are equivalent. Applying this weight ensures that analyses of the incentive experiment can isolate the true effect of the differential incentives, without distortion from the intentional IMD-based oversampling of the control group.

6. Analysing the data

There are a number of demographic and analysis variables that users may find useful. These are listed below.

Table 6.3 Demographic variables

DVSex25	Respondent's sex
RAgeCat / RAgeCat2	Respondent's age group
RaceOri4	Respondent's ethnicity
ReligSum	Respondent's religion
ReconAct / ReconSum	Respondent's economic activity (priority coded)
HhAdGpd	Number of adults in household
HhChlGpd_SEArchive	Number of children in household
BestNatU2_SEArchive	Nationality that best describes the respondent
DisActDV	Whether respondent has a disability that affects their daily life

EmployB	Whether respondent an employee or self-employed
LegMarStE	Respondent's legal marital status
ReligFamSum	Religion respondent brought up in
EmplStatDV	Respondent's employment status
RspgndrDV	Respondent's gender
UnionDV	Respondent membership of a trade union or staff association
RClassGP	Respondent's NS-SEC classification (self-coded)
Country	Respondent's country
Gor_txt	Respondent's region

Table 6.2 Analysis variables

Popdens	Population density (Local Authority Level)
Perc_owned	Percentage owner-occupier (Census Output Area)
Stratum_name	Level of area deprivation by region
BSAIncentiveExpGrp	Whether in control or experiment incentive group
BSAIncentiveValueFlag	Respondent's incentive value
IntMode	Whether completed survey by web or telephone
QnrVersion	Respondent's questionnaire version
Vchtype	Respondent's preference for receiving voucher
NCOOutcome	Respondent's survey outcome
Simd2020v2_quintile	Scotland IMD quintiles (2010)
Eimd2019_quintile	England IMD quintiles (2019)
Wimd2019_quintile	Wales IMD quintiles (2019)
Nimd2017_quintile	Northern Ireland IMD quintiles (2017)
Ruc21_SEArchive	Rural/urban status
No_of_reminders	Number of reminders sent
Survey_started_letters	When survey started in relation to letters sent
Survey_finished_letters	When survey finished in relation to letters sent
Fieldwork_week	Week in fieldwork when survey started
PSU	Primary sampling unit

Please note that some survey variables have been back-coded. Some of these variables are not present in the dataset but were used to derive some DVs that are included in the data.

In addition, please note that some variables have been edited, for example collapsing their categories together, to ensure the data is not disclosive.

7. Further information

For further information on anything contained in this booklet please contact: bsa@natcen.ac.uk

